Apostolic Appointment

Where does doctrinal authority in the church come from?

"If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person, he should acknowledge that what I write to you is the Lord's command."
(1 Corinthians 14:37)

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One Question Underneath

Is authority conferred → or generated?

Before "who may do what," a prior question: where does teaching authority in the church come from?

Only two possible answers. It is CONFERRED (delivered, handed down, appointed) → or GENERATED (produced by something in the person).

Movement	The claim	The move
Montanists (2nd c.)	Direct revelation → "the Spirit speaks now"	**GENERATED**
Quakers (17th c.)	The inner light speaks through anyone	**GENERATED**
Revivalism (19th c.)	Demonstrated fruit → "look, God is using them"	**GENERATED**
Modern (20th c.)	Reconstructed background; cultural trajectory	**GENERATED**

Four centuries, four vocabularies → one move: authority relocated FROM appointment TO something claimable without it → revelation, fruit, insight, progress.

None of these is stupid, and some of the people were godly. The question is not "were they sincere?" (Week 3!) but "is that where the New Testament LOCATES authority?"

Paul Closes the Door

1 Corinthians 14 → gifting does not adjudicate order

The setting matters: 1 Corinthians 12–14 is THE gifts passage → tongues, prophecy, the Spirit's manifestations. And right there, Paul writes:

"If anyone considers himself a prophet or spiritual person, he should acknowledge that what I write to you is the Lord's command. If someone does not recognize this, he is not recognized."
(1 Corinthians 14:37–38)

Look at whom Paul names: not skeptics → **prophets and spiritual people**. The two most impressive credentials in that church. And he subordinates BOTH to what he writes. He does not deny they have gifts → the Corinthian gifts were real. He denies that gifts adjudicate ***order***.

And v.38 attaches a sanction: refusing to recognize apostolic authority is itself disqualifying. So every claim that bypasses the apostolic word → "the Spirit told me," "look at the fruit," "we've grown past this" → runs into the wall Paul built here, in the gifts chapter itself. Gifting is given to the whole body; **authority is conferred by the apostolic word.**

Deposit and Handoff

Authority is delivered and received → never self-generated

The New Testament describes authority as a deposit passed down a chain:

- Appointed, not attained → ***"For this I was appointed a preacher and apostle"*** **(1 Tim 2:7)**
- Traditions delivered & held →

"maintain the traditions just as I passed them on to you" **(1 Cor 11:2)**

- Entrusted to teach others →

"what you heard from me… entrust to faithful people who will be competent to teach others" **(2 Tim 2:2)**

- Once for all entrusted →

"the faith that was once for all entrusted to the saints" **(Jude 3)**

The pattern is deposit → handoff, never discovery. 2 Timothy 2:2 shows four generations in one verse: Paul → Timothy → faithful people → others. A relay, not a spring.

The early church kept exactly this question. Not "who has the gift?" but "who was appointed?"

- Origen concedes women may have the prophetic gift → and still restricts the venue.
- Hippolytus ties ordination to liturgical function: hands are laid where there is a governing role, not merely a gift.

This is why the course's title phrase fits: the whole apostleship exists "to bring about the obedience of faith" (Rom 1:5). The apostolic word is the conferring authority → and receiving it is itself an act of obedient faith.

The Trajectory Argument → and Why It Inverts

The strongest objection, met honestly

The objection (state it at full strength): "Scripture regulated slavery without condemning it; the church later moved past slavery. Gender order is the same → a cultural waypoint we've moved beyond." This deserves a real answer, not a dodge.

Grant the premise: the church DID read the slavery texts badly for centuries, and the correction came late. That should humble everyone. So why doesn't the analogy carry?

Because of WHERE each is grounded:

- Slavery → Paul never grounds it in creation. There is no verse "for the master was formed first." The anchor is cultural.
- Assembly order → Paul grounds it in creation, TWICE: *"Adam was formed first, then Eve" (1 Tim 2:13); "woman came from man… for man" (1 Cor 11:8–9).*

Cultural anchors drag. Creation anchors don't.

So, the analogy inverts: the very feature that let the church move past slavery (no creation grounding) is the feature the assembly texts conspicuously HAVE. Same tool, opposite result.

Discussion

Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

1. Why is "God is clearly using them" not, by itself, a warrant for office? Where does that reasoning go wrong → and where is it partly right?

2. Where do WE feel the pull of results-based validation → in ministry, in decisions, in judging what's true? Is it always wrong?

Contested-ground rule: *reason from the text, not from certainty. Disagreement is welcome; scoring points is not.*

Read Like a Berean

For next week → the harder question

For next week, read → slowly, both sides in view:

- **1 Timothy 2:1–15** → what does Paul restrict, what reason does he give (v.13), and what does he NOT say?
- **1 Corinthians 11:2–16** → note v3 & v.5: women pray and prophesy. How does that reason fit with restriction?

Next week: *God's Created Order → the narrow, careful question of roles in the assembly, and the full breadth of women's ministry Scripture shows.*

This week in one sentence:

Gifting is given to the whole body; authority is conferred by the apostolic word. Deposit, not discovery.

"what I write to you is the Lord's command."
(1 Corinthians 14:37)

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